unenforceable, or outdated. This is the authorization equivalent of identity sprawl: Decisions that once reflected deliberate choices now persist simply because no one is responsible for them.

But governance does more than define ownership: It also oversees the controls themselves. Modern authorization systems treat policies as code, which means they carry all the risks and benefits of software engineering. Policy governance sets the technical standards for how policies are written, tested, and deployed: enforcing code reviews, schema validation, automated testing, and continuous integration. These practices ensure that policies are not only correct in principle but also safe in operation. In this way, governance spans both the human and the machine, aligning human intent with automated enforcement.

A mature governance framework transforms authorization from a routine task into a managed discipline. It clarifies roles—such as policy authors, reviewers, approvers, and access control coordinators—and assigns accountability for each stage of the policy lifecycle. It establishes standards for policy quality and implements regular review cycles. Additionally, it links human judgment with automated assurance by pairing decision logs and testing pipelines with human oversight and policy attestation. In essence, governance ensures that each policy decision can be traced back to a business rationale, a technical control, and a designated owner.

Policy governance also plays a crucial role in building trust and ensuring compliance. Regulators, auditors, and partners increasingly expect organizations to show not only that policies exist but also that they are actively governed. Logs, version histories, and review records provide an evidence trail that links system behavior to deliberate governance actions. For ACME, this was more than just a compliance requirement; it became a competitive advantage: When customers asked how ACME protected their data, the company could demonstrate both the policies that enforced access and the governance processes that maintained those policies.

Ultimately, governance enables authorization to evolve safely. New features, integrations, and regulations will always create pressure to change access rules. Governance offers the mechanism to make those changes intentionally,